



ServiceNow Overview and Introduction Notes

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Module 1: Introduction & Platform Overview

1. Introduction to ServiceNow

History and Origin

- **Founded:** 2004 by **Fred Luddy** (former CTO of Peregrine Systems).
- **Original Name:** Glidesoft.
- **Headquarters:** Santa Clara, California.
- **Evolution:** Originally designed as an innovative ticketing system for IT (ITSM), it has evolved into a comprehensive **Enterprise Service Management (ESM)** platform.

The "Why" Behind ServiceNow

Before ServiceNow, enterprise departments (IT, HR, Facilities) operated in silos using disparate tools, emails, and spreadsheets to manage work. ServiceNow was created to break down these silos by offering a **Single System of Record**—a unified platform where all distinct business units can interact, share data, and automate workflows.

2. What is ServiceNow?

Definition

ServiceNow is a cloud-based **Platform as a Service (PaaS)** that provides software solutions for Enterprise Service Management. While it is delivered as **SaaS** (Software as a Service) to end-users, it is a **PaaS** for Administrators and Developers, allowing them to build, modify, and automate custom applications on top of the "Now Platform."

Core Value Proposition

- **Workflow Automation:** It replaces unstructured work patterns (emails, spreadsheets, hallway conversations) with intelligent, structured, and automated workflows.
- **System of Action:** It sits on top of existing data (Systems of Record like SAP, Oracle) and acts as the engagement layer where work actually gets done.

Key Architectural Concept: Multi-Instance

This is the most critical technical concept for an Administrator to understand regarding the ServiceNow infrastructure.

- **Multi-Instance Architecture:** Unlike many cloud competitors (like Salesforce) that use Multi-Tenant architecture (shared database), ServiceNow utilizes a **Multi-Instance** architecture.

- **How it works:** Each customer (tenant) receives their own unique software stack (Application Nodes) and their own isolated database.
- **Benefits:**
 - **Data Isolation:** Your data is physically separated from other customers.
 - **Performance:** A heavy load on another customer's instance does not impact yours.
 - **Flexibility:** You can upgrade your instance on your own schedule.

The "Now Platform"

ServiceNow is often described as "a platform of platforms." It uses a **Single Data Model**.

- This means that Incident Management, HR Service Delivery, and Security Operations all share the same database structure, user table, and configuration management database (CMDB).
- **Result:** Seamless reporting and logic transfer between different business units.

Module 2: Utility & Business Scenario

1. Why is ServiceNow Used?

ServiceNow is primarily used to drive **Digital Transformation**. It allows organizations to replace manual, unstructured work patterns with intelligent, automated workflows.

The Core Problem:

In many organizations, departments work in silos. Work is often tracked via:

- **Emails:** "Hey, can you fix this?" (Hard to track, easy to lose).
- **Spreadsheets:** "Project Tracker v3_final.xlsx" (Static data, often outdated).
- **Phone Calls/Hallway Conversations:** (No record of the request).

The ServiceNow Solution:

ServiceNow is used to centralize these requests into a **Service-Oriented** model.

Key Objectives:

1. **Single System of Record:** It serves as the single source of truth for IT assets, user data, and service requests.
2. **Standardization:** It ensures that every request follows a specific, pre-approved process (Standard Operating Procedure).
3. **Automation:** It removes manual routing. If a server goes down, ServiceNow can automatically create an Incident and assign it to the Server Team without human intervention.
4. **Transparency & Reporting:** It allows management to see exactly how long tasks take, who is working on them, and where bottlenecks exist (SLA Tracking).
5. **Self-Service:** It shifts the "Left" (Shift-Left strategy), empowering end-users to resolve their own issues via a Knowledge Base or Service Portal, reducing the load on service desks.

2. Business Scenario: "GlobalTech Corp"

To understand the power of ServiceNow, consider the following "Onboarding" scenario at a fictional company, **GlobalTech Corp**.

The "Before" State (Without ServiceNow)

- **The Situation:** A new employee, Alice, is hired.
- **The Process:**
 - HR sends an email to the IT Manager: "Alice starts Monday."
 - The IT Manager writes a sticky note to configure a laptop but forgets to tell the Network Team to create her email account.
 - HR calls the Facilities Manager to ask for a desk, but the Facilities Manager is on leave.
- **The Result:** Alice arrives on Monday. She has no laptop, no email, and no desk. The departments blame each other. The process was **manual, opaque, and prone to error**.

The "After" State (With ServiceNow)

- **The Situation:** Alice is hired.
- **The Process (The Workflow):**
 1. **Initiation:** The HR Manager logs into the **Service Portal** and fills out a single "New Hire Request" form.
 2. **Automation (The Flow):** ServiceNow automatically triggers a workflow.
 3. **Parallel Tasks:**

- **Task A (IT):** A task is automatically assigned to the IT Service Desk: "Provision Laptop."
 - **Task B (System Admin):** An automatic script runs to generate Alice's Active Directory account and email.
 - **Task C (Facilities):** A task is assigned to the Facilities group: "Prepare Desk 4B."
4. **Notifications:** As each team completes their task, the HR Manager receives a real-time notification on their dashboard.
- **The Result:** Alice arrives on Monday. Her equipment is ready. The entire process is audit-trailed. If IT had been slow, an **SLA (Service Level Agreement)** breach would have alerted upper management.

Module 3: History & Platform Versions

1. History of ServiceNow

Founding Story

- **Founder: Fred Luddy**, the former CTO of Peregrine Systems.
- **Year:** Founded in **2004**.
- **Original Name: Glidesoft.**
- **Vision:** Fred Luddy wanted to create a tool that ordinary people (non-coders) could use to build workflows without dealing with complex complexity. This was the birth of the "Low-Code/No-Code" philosophy ServiceNow still uses today.

The "Glide" Legacy (Technical Relevance)

- Why does this history matter to an Admin?
- In the system, you will constantly see the word **"Glide"** in technical scripts and internal components (e.g., `GlideRecord`, `GlideSystem`, `GlideAjax`).
- This is a reference to the original company name, **Glidesoft**.

Key Milestones

- **2005:** First customer onboarded.
- **2012:** ServiceNow went public (IPO) on the New York Stock Exchange (NOW).
- **Evolution:** Started strictly as an IT Service Management (ITSM) ticketing tool. Over the years, it expanded into IT Operations (ITOM), HR (HRSD), Customer Service (CSM), and Security (SecOps).

2. ServiceNow Versions & Release Cycle



Naming Convention

ServiceNow follows a distinct naming convention for its major upgrades. They are named after **major world cities** in **alphabetical order**.

Release Cadence

- **Frequency:** ServiceNow releases **two major upgrades per year**.
- **Timing:** Typically, these occur in **Q1/Q2** (Spring) and **Q3/Q4** (Fall).

Recent & Upcoming Versions (The Alphabetical Pattern)

To show the progression, here is the sequence of recent releases:

- **Q** - Quebec
- **R** - Rome
- **S** - San Diego
- **T** - Tokyo
- **U** - Utah
- **V** - Vancouver
- **W** - Washington D.C.
- **X** - Xanadu
- **Y** - Yokohama (*Predicted/Upcoming*)
- **Z** - Zurich (*Predicted/Upcoming*)

(Note: Once the alphabet reaches Z, the cycle will restart at A with a new naming theme).

Support Model (N-1 Policy)

ServiceNow generally supports the current version and the version immediately preceding it.

- This mandates that customers must upgrade their instances roughly once a year to stay supported and receive security patches.
- **End of Life (EOL):** When a version is too old, ServiceNow will automatically schedule an upgrade for the instance to ensure security compliance.

Module 4: Key Platform Features

1. Low-Code / No-Code Development

ServiceNow is built on the philosophy of "Citizen Development." It allows users with little to no programming knowledge to build functional applications using drag-and-drop interfaces.

- **Feature: App Engine Studio.**
- **Real-World Application:** An HR Manager wants a simple application to track "Employee Gift Requests." Instead of hiring a developer to write code, the Admin uses App Engine to drag-and-drop a data table, create a form, and publish the app in minutes.
- **Benefit:** Reduces the IT backlog and speeds up digital transformation.

2. Workflow Automation

This is the engine that drives business logic. It replaces manual routing with automated logic using natural language (e.g., "If this happens, then do that").

- **Feature: Flow Designer** (Replaces the legacy "Workflow Editor").
- **Real-World Application:** When a user requests "Adobe Photoshop" software:
 1. **Trigger:** Request is submitted.
 2. **Action 1:** System checks if the software license is available.
 3. **Action 2:** If cost > \$100, send an Approval Email to the manager.
 4. **Action 3:** Upon approval, automatically assign the installation task to IT.
- **Benefit:** Eliminates human error and reduces process time.

3. Reporting & Performance Analytics

ServiceNow does not just store data; it visualizes it to help management make decisions.

- **Feature: Reports & Dashboards.**

- *Real-World Application:* A Service Desk Manager has a dashboard showing a real-time pie chart of "Incidents by Priority." They can instantly see if there is a spike in "Critical" issues today.
- **Feature: Performance Analytics (PA).**
 - *Difference:* Standard Reporting shows the **current** state (Snapshot). Performance Analytics shows **trends over time**.
 - *Real-World Application:* A CIO wants to know, "Are we resolving tickets faster this month than we were six months ago?" PA visualizes this historical trend.

4. Integration

ServiceNow rarely operates alone; it needs to "talk" to other tools (like Jira, Slack, Microsoft AD, Workday).

- **Feature: IntegrationHub (Spokes).**
- **Real-World Application:**
 - **Password Reset:** A user forgets their password. They click "Reset" in ServiceNow. IntegrationHub talks to **Microsoft Active Directory** to actually change the password on the server instantly.
 - **Communication:** When a "Critical" incident occurs, ServiceNow automatically posts a message in the company's **Microsoft Teams** or **Slack** channel to alert the engineering team.

5. Artificial Intelligence

ServiceNow embeds AI into the platform to assist agents and end-users.

- **Feature: Virtual Agent (Chatbot).**
 - *Real-World Application:* A user visits the portal at 2:00 AM. Instead of waiting for a human, they chat with the Virtual Agent. The bot asks, "What do you need?" and automatically orders a new mouse or searches the Knowledge Base for them.
- **Feature: Predictive Intelligence.**
 - *Real-World Application:* An employee sends an email saying, "My printer is jammed." The AI reads the text, recognizes the keyword "printer," and automatically categorizes the ticket as "Hardware" and routes it to the "Printers Team" without human intervention.

6. The CMDB (Configuration Management Database)

This is the backbone of IT Operations within ServiceNow.

- **Feature: CMDB.**
- **Definition:** A series of tables that store all the infrastructure data (Computers, Servers, Routers, Applications) and the **relationships** between them.
- **Real-World Application:**
 - A server named "Server-001" goes down.
 - Because of the CMDB, the Admin can look at a **Dependency Map** and see that "Server-001" hosts the "Email Application."
 - **Result:** IT knows that "Email is down" before users even start complaining.

Module 5: Career Opportunities & Ecosystem

1. Market Overview: The "Skills Gap"

ServiceNow is currently one of the fastest-growing enterprise software companies in the world. As it replaces legacy systems in Fortune 500 companies, the demand for skilled professionals has outpaced the supply.

- **The Opportunity:** There is a significant "talent shortage." Organizations are willing to pay a premium for certified professionals because the platform is critical to their daily operations.
- **Stability:** Because ServiceNow becomes the "backbone" of a company's operations (IT, HR, Security), it is rarely replaced once installed, offering high job stability.

2. Core Career Roles

While "Administrator" is often the starting point, the ServiceNow ecosystem offers several distinct career paths.

A. ServiceNow Administrator (The Keeper of the Keys)

- **Focus:** Day-to-day maintenance, user management, form configuration, report creation, and troubleshooting.
- **Skills:** Platform fundamentals, UI policies, basic logic (no heavy coding).

- **Typical Environment:** Internal IT team of a specific company (e.g., An Admin for a Bank).

B. ServiceNow Developer (The Builder)

- **Focus:** Writing code to extend functionality beyond out-of-the-box features.
- **Skills:** JavaScript (essential), Angular, HTML/CSS, API Integrations (REST/SOAP).
- **Progression:** Admins often learn scripting to become Developers.

C. ServiceNow Business Analyst (The Translator)

- **Focus:** Bridging the gap between business stakeholders and the technical team. They gather requirements (e.g., "HR needs a new onboarding form") and translate them into technical stories for developers.
- **Skills:** Process mapping, agile methodology, communication, platform knowledge (knowing what is possible).

D. Implementation Specialist / Consultant

- **Focus:** Working for consultancy firms (Partners) to install ServiceNow for new customers. They travel (virtually or physically) from project to project.
- **Skills:** Deep knowledge of specific products (ITSM, HRSD, CSM) and consulting soft skills.

E. ServiceNow Architect (The Strategist)

- **Focus:** High-level design. They decide *how* the system should be built to remain scalable and secure. They oversee the work of developers to ensure best practices.
- **Skills:** System architecture, governance, long-term strategy. This is usually a senior-level role (5-10+ years experience).

3. Specialized Product Lines (Niche Careers)

You do not have to be a "Generalist." You can specialize in specific modules to increase your value.

- **ITSM Specialist:** Focuses on the core IT ticketing (Incident, Change, Problem).
- **HRSD Specialist:** Focuses on HR Service Delivery (Onboarding, Employee Center).

- **SecOps (Security Operations):** Focuses on Vulnerability Response and Security Incidents. (High demand due to cybersecurity needs).
- **ITOM (IT Operations Management):** Focuses on Discovery, Service Mapping, and Cloud Management.

4. Who Hires ServiceNow Professionals?

There are three main categories of employers:

1. **Customers (End Clients):** Companies like Coca-Cola, Disney, or major banks that use ServiceNow to run their business. They hire Admins/Devs to maintain their internal instance.
2. **Partners (Consultancies):** Companies like Accenture, Deloitte, KPMG, or specialized boutique firms. They sell services to implement ServiceNow for others.
3. **ServiceNow (The Company):** Working directly for the vendor in sales, product development, or support.

Module 6: Product Portfolio Overview

1. The Workflow Architecture

ServiceNow organizes its vast array of products into four primary "Workflows." As an Admin, it is critical to understand which workflow a specific application belongs to, as this affects licensing, plugins, and the user audience.

The four main Workflows are:

1. **IT Workflows** (The technical backbone)
2. **Employee Workflows** (The internal experience)
3. **Customer Workflows** (The external experience)
4. **Creator Workflows** (The development engine)

2. IT Workflows (The Core)

This is the most common starting point for companies. It is designed to modernize and automate IT operations.

- **ITSM (IT Service Management):**
 - *Purpose:* Managing IT services and end-user support.
 - *Key Apps:* Incident, Problem, Change, Request, Service Catalog, Knowledge Management.
 - *Scenario:* A user's laptop breaks (Incident) or a server needs an upgrade (Change).
- **ITOM (IT Operations Management):**
 - *Purpose:* Managing the infrastructure (Servers, Cloud, Networks) using automation and visibility.
 - *Key Apps:* Discovery (finding devices on the network), Service Mapping (connecting devices to business services), Event Management (monitoring health).
 - *Scenario:* Discovering all servers in a data center automatically without manual entry.
- **ITAM (IT Asset Management):**
 - *Purpose:* Tracking the financial and physical lifecycle of assets.
 - *Key Apps:* Hardware Asset Management (HAM), Software Asset Management (SAM).
 - *Scenario:* Checking if the company has enough expensive Adobe licenses for new hires (SAM).
- **SecOps (Security Operations):**
 - *Purpose:* bridging the gap between security teams and IT.
 - *Key Apps:* Security Incident Response (SIR), Vulnerability Response.
 - *Scenario:* A firewall detects a breach. SecOps automatically creates a security ticket and assigns it to the security analyst.
- **GRC (Governance, Risk, and Compliance) / IRM:**
 - *Purpose:* Managing audits and ensuring the company follows laws (GDPR, SOX).
 - *Scenario:* Preparing for an annual ISO audit by tracking all control tests in ServiceNow.

3. Employee Workflows (The Internal Experience)

Designed to provide a unified experience for employees, treating them like customers.

- **HRSD (HR Service Delivery):**

- *Purpose:* Managing the employee lifecycle and HR requests.
- *Key Apps:* Case Management, Onboarding/Offboarding, Employee Center.
- *Scenario:* An employee requests "Maternity Leave." The system creates a private HR case, tasks payroll, and updates their profile.
- **WSD (Workplace Service Delivery):**
 - *Purpose:* Managing physical office spaces.
 - *Scenario:* An employee books a desk or a conference room using their mobile app before coming into the office.

4. Customer Workflows (The External Experience)

Designed to support external customers (consumers or B2B clients).

- **CSM (Customer Service Management):**
 - *Purpose:* Solving issues for external customers. Unlike ITSM (internal), this connects customers to the middle office.
 - *Scenario:* A customer buys a router that stops working. They log a ticket on the company website. The agent sees the customer's warranty status immediately.
- **FSM (Field Service Management):**
 - *Purpose:* Managing technicians who travel to physical locations.
 - *Scenario:* A cable internet provider dispatches a truck to a house. The technician uses the ServiceNow Mobile Agent app to clock in and close the job.

5. Creator Workflows (The Build Engine)

These are tools used to build *new* applications that don't exist Out-of-the-Box.

- **App Engine:**
 - The low-code environment for building custom apps.
 - *Example:* Building a "Parking Spot Reservation" app for your specific office needs.
- **Automation Engine (IntegrationHub):**
 - The tools used to connect ServiceNow to third-party systems (Microsoft, Zoom, Jira, Slack).

